

Figure 3: New Project

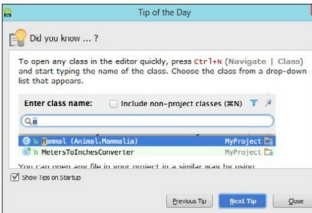


Figure 4: Tip of the day



Figure 5: Preview of different layouts

at the spot from where you can start off a new Android Project (refer to Figure 3). Among other interesting things about Android Studio is the ‘Tip of the day’ section (refer to Figure 4), which makes you familiar with the IDE.

Now, let’s focus on some specific features that come with Android Studio (and quoting directly from the Android Developers Web page):

- Gradle-based build support.
- Android-specific refactoring and quick fixes.
- Lint tools to catch performance, usability, version compatibility and other problems.
- ProGuard and app-signing capabilities.

- Template-based wizards to create common Android designs and components.
- A rich layout editor that allows you to drag-and-drop UI components, preview layouts on multiple screen configurations, and much more.
- Built-in support for Google Cloud Platform, making it easy to integrate Google Cloud Messaging and App Engine as server-side components.

One of the major changes with respect to Eclipse is the use of Gradle. Previously, Android used Ant for build, but with Android Studio, this task has been taken over by Gradle. In last year’s Google I/O, sources at Google had talked about the new Android build system — Gradle. To quote from the Gradle website: “Google selected Gradle as the foundation of the Android SDK build system because it provides flexibility along with the ability to define common standards for Android builds. With Gradle, Android developers can use a simple, declarative DSL to configure Gradle builds supporting a wide variety of Android devices and App stores. With a simple, declarative DSL, Gradle developers have access to a single, authoritative build that powers both the Android Studio IDE and builds from the command-line.” Owing to Gradle, people will also notice a change in the project structure as compared to the project structure in Eclipse. Everything now resides inside the SRC folder. But from a developer’s perspective, it is essentially all still the same.

The other major, and rather useful, change is the ability to preview the layout on different screen sizes (refer to Figure 5, as shown during the Google I/O last year). While retaining the drag-and-drop designer function, the text mode has the preview pane to the right which allows for previewing the layout on various screen sizes. There is also an option for making a landscape variation design for the same app without having to do anything much on the code level.

This is just the tip of the iceberg, and the features discussed above are amongst the major changes in terms of build and layout designing. I would encourage zealous developers who want to try out this IDE to visit the Android developers’ page and check out the Android Studio section. It is definitely a different way to approach Android app development, with the focus shifting towards development rather than configuration and management. **END** 

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